Course Observation Feedback Form

Instructor: Dr. Devontae Baxter	**Course Name: ASTR 20A: Introduction to Astrophysics**
Date of Observation: November 4, 2025	**Number of students: 40 (25 present)**
Observer: Dr. Erilynn Heinrichsen	**Session Topic: Earth and Moon**

Procedure: Peer review of instruction was requested by Dr. Devontae Baxter and conducted by the Teaching and Learning Commons Engaged Teaching Hub at UC San Diego. For this service, an academic professional with training and experience in evidence-based instructional practices and design reviews a portion of instruction or instructional materials and provides non-evaluative, formative feedback to the instructor based on pre-identified goals and best practices.

This review of instruction was based on observation of an in-person class session. Detailed notes were shared in a post-review consultation, along with the feedback form below aligning observations with attributes of effective instruction. A summary of the comments and formative feedback are provided for the instructor at the end of the document.

Planning & Organization *How was the class session structured? What strategies did the instructor use to present information and help students make connections?*	**Formative Assessment Strategies** *What opportunities did students have to engage with material (either individually or collaboratively)? In what ways did students get feedback on their understanding?*
Dr. Baxter **planned class time effectively** to explain content and allow student engagement. Specifically, he: ● Started class on time and welcomed students. ● Used an introductory slide to establish context and share an image to hook students' attention. ● Previewed the class session with clear learning outcomes ● Spoke and moved through the session at a pace without feeling rushed ● Integrated very effective visuals throughout the class session to both demonstrate and enhance the concepts, as well as to spark interest and wonder ● Effectively helped students stay focused in the end of class by wrapping up with final polling questions ● Started and ended class with reminders about deadlines both within class and	Dr. Baxter provided an **opportunity for formative assessment** when he: ● Integrated a **multi-step scaffolded think-pair-share activity** where students had the opportunity to both practice calculations and coding, and then interpret the results to discuss potential real-life actions: "based off those numbers, should we prioritize limiting energy use, slowing population growth, or space-based solar harvesting technology?" ● Provided immediate feedback by discussing student responses and contributions. ● Ended the session with true/false polling questions to assess comprehension of topics related to the session learning outcomes, allowing students to show a fist or a single raised finger to vote.

university-level drop deadline, and project logistics, and deadlines. The instructor demonstrated confidence in disciplinary knowledge and skills, including: ● Appeared to have mastery of subject and student questions ● Showed no reliance on notes or slides when talking about content ● Recognized aspects of the content that are challenging for learners ● Modeled disciplinary thinking for students by explaining his thought process, both in the coding calculations and in the interpretation of data	
Questioning Strategies *How did the instructor make space for and respond to students' questions? What types of questions did the instructor pose, and what strategies did they use to invite responses?*	**Inclusive Teaching Practices** *What practices did the instructor use to create a safe, welcoming, and equitable environment? In what ways were students' voices and identities incorporated into the class session?*
Dr. Baxter **used questioning techniques to engage students and check for understanding**. For example, he: ● Provided opportunities for students to chime in on questions posed during explanations in the latter half of class ● Used polling to assess student learning outcomes at the end of class ● Used humor and fostered rapport when interacting with students Dr. Baxter paused regularly to **invite student questions** and responded positively. For example, he: ● Regularly had a slide after each major concept to invite questions ● Responded positively to questions ● Used appropriate wait time following inviting questions to allow students processing time	Dr. Baxter **created a welcoming and respectful environment for student learning**. This was shown during the class through: ● Showing appreciation for student feedback offered through mid-quarter survey ● Emphasizing the larger purpose or value of the material being covered ● Allowing ample time for any in-class activities ● Effectively communicating complex topics with analogies and examples that students of all levels of prior knowledge could relate to. For example, sharing that the earth is like an onion both as a way to introduce layers, and as a way to summarize in the end. Another excellent example was in describing the p- and s-waves and the ultrasound to see into the earth's layers ● Integrating accessibility measures to empower all to participate, including providing advance access to slides to support diverse learning needs and note-taking preferences.

	• Moving around during the think-pair-share activity to be available to students and taking a seat near a student, when possible, to get at their level. • Very clearly communicating with students about deadlines and expectations for an upcoming project, which takes the onus off the student to find out information that is often considered a "hidden curriculum" and thus creating a more equitable learning experience. • Breaking down barriers between instructor and student by speaking in a conversational tone both during the lecture and in talking individually with students, using welcoming body language, incorporating humor, and sharing excitement about the topic

Summary:

Strengths observed during the class session:
Dr. Baxter demonstrated expertise in facilitating a class session that **encouraged students to connect with the content through both analogies and visuals,**. This was exemplified through:

- **Effective communication of complex topics:** Dr. Baxter did a tremendous job of using analogies and engaging stories to help make complex topics feel attainable for students at all levels. These were often used when introducing a topic, and then revisited throughout to keep students connected. Dr. Baxter clearly has a joy of communicating science, and this shone through in these moments. Additionally, images, graphics, and videos were used effectively to enhance and engage. These brought the topic into reality and Dr. Baxter directly integrated the images into the lecture so that they improved the explanation and helped students conceptualize it in a different way.

- **Scaffolded student processing through an activity:** Dr. Baxter integrated an activity in the middle of the class session that encouraged students to think through complex information on two distinct but related levels: calculations and thinking through real-life actions. This was an effective way to scaffold the student engagement with the topic and appeal both to the importance of being able to calculate, allow for error in the calculations, and think rationally about the actions that might result.

- **Structure and flow:** Dr. Baxter did an excellent job of structuring and facilitating the class session so that it flowed smoothly and was engaging to follow. Starting with actionable and specific session learning outcomes helped the students orient their learning for the class session and know what to expect.

- **Clear communication of expectations**: Dr. Baxter took time to very clearly break down the expectations and requirements of an upcoming project and sharing deadlines multiple times - this creates a more equitable learning space, where assumptions are not made of students and their prior knowledge of university structures and expectations.

Challenges observed and specific recommendations that would enhance the learning environment in future class sessions and/or future courses:
In a follow up conversation after the observation, we discussed a few concrete ideas based on the observations. These were related to:

- **Additional engagement ideas**: Building upon the activities and rapport already present, we discussed a few other ways to engage students who might not opt to answer or ask questions, such as:
    - Getting students talking earlier in the class session might make them more likely to speak up with questions.
    - Invite additional student responses or predictions into the learning, similar to what was done toward the end of class – for example, seeing how many layers of the earth they could name on their own. In doing this, you might invite students to briefly formulate their thoughts on paper or with a peer before responding in the larger class, as some might benefit from additional time or structure to process the information and decide to engage.
    - When inviting student questions, could integrate a “1-2 minute pause” between key concepts, inviting students to review their notes from that concept and identify any remaining questions or areas that need clarifying.
    - Integrating additional polling questions throughout the lecture, perhaps after each learning outcome or topic has been covered.

- **Returning to the learning outcomes/goals for students**: The outcomes for the session were well crafted, actionable, and specific. Bringing these back in throughout the session might help students organize and process their learning. This could be connected to polling questions or a 1 min pause for students to review notes and see if they have any questions about that outcome.

- **Restating contributions and projecting voice**: To help engage those sitting near the back, you might consider using a microphone or intentionally projecting the voice. Likewise, restating student contributions might help those in the back hear those and

be more likely to contribute as well. One way to do this would be to restate student contributions by saying something like “what I’m hearing is…” as that will both aid others in hearing the contribution and also allow the student contributing to confirm or clarify their question or comment if needed.